WAR ROOM COUNCIL

PayPal AI Hackathon — War-Room Intelligence Bible

PayPal AI Hackathon · TALOS Master Intelligence

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> **Verdict:** The **PayPal AI Hackathon** (Oct 1 – Nov 12, 2026; **$69,750** across 24 prizes; **24,754 registered participants** on Devpost) is not a generic "build an AI chatbot that generates a payment link" contest. Under CEO Alex Chriss, EVP & Chief Platform Officer Srini Venkatesan, and SVP & Chief AI Officer Prakhar Mehrotra, PayPal is racing to establish **PayPal Agentic Commerce Services (ACS)**, the **PayPal MCP Server (** `mcp.paypal.com` **/** `@paypal/mcp` **)**, the **PayPal Agent Toolkit (** `@paypal/agent-toolkit` **)**, **PayPal JS SDK v6**, and **PayPal World (UPI interoperability)** as the default financial trust and settlement layer for autonomous AI agents before Stripe's Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP) and Visa Intelligent Commerce lock up the developer mindshare. Because Official Rules §6 breaks all ties in strict sequential order—**(1) Technological Implementation -> (2) Design -> (3) Potential Impact -> (4) Innovation/Idea -> (5) Presentation**—and §8 caps any single project at **1 Grand Prize (or 1 Honorable Mention) + 1 Sponsor Prize ($17,000 max cash per project)** while §4 permits **up to 2 submissions per participant**, the optimal winning strategy is a two-submission portfolio: **Submission #1 (** `TALOS` **)** in **Domain 1 (AI Agents & Agentic Commerce — Rank #1 Winnability** `8.73/10` **)** targeting the **$12,000 1st Place Grand Prize + $5,000 AG Grid Best Use Prize ($17,000)**, and **Submission #2 (** `CivicTrace Escrow` **in D5 Social Impact or** `ChargeShield AI` **in D3 Business Solutions)** targeting a **$5,000 Honorable Mention (** `Most Impactful` **/** `Best Use of PayPal + AI` **) + $1,500 Channel3 or $1,000 Bryntum/APIMatic Prize ($6,000–$6,500)** for a combined **$23,500 cash ceiling**.

Part 1 — Official Facts

At a glance

Field	Value
Organiser	**PayPal** (`paypal.com` / `developer.paypal.com`) — Platform managed by **Devpost, Inc.**
Co-organisers / partners	**10 Official Sponsors & Partners**: **Prize Sponsors (5)**: AG Grid (`$10,000` across 5 winners), APIMatic (`$3,000` cash + 3x 6-mo Biz Subs across 3 winners), Bryntum (`$3,000` across 3 winners), Channel3 (`$1,500` , 1 winner), Render (`$2,250` Render Credits across 3 winners). **Ecosystem & Jury Partners (5)**: Elastic (`searchlabs`), Postman, KERNEL (`onkernel.com`), Astropods, Zapier.
Mode	**100% Online Global Hackathon** (hosted on Devpost)
Dates	**Submissions Open**: Oct 1, 2026 (9:15 am PDT) · **Early Eligibility Check**: Nov 5, 2026 · **Submission Deadline**: Nov 12, 2026 (12:00 pm PST / Nov 13, 2026 @ 1:30 am IST) · **Stage 2 Jury Scoring**: Dec 1 – Dec 15, 2026 · **Winners Announced**: On or around Dec 21, 2026 (12:00 pm PST)
Eligibility	Individuals at least **18 years old** (or age of majority) in eligible jurisdictions (**India, US, UK, Canada, Brazil, EU, etc. are 100% eligible**). Excludes sanctioned jurisdictions (Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Syria, Crimea/Donetsk/Luhansk), Russia, Belarus, and PayPal/Sponsor/Judge employees & immediate family.
Team size	Solo or Teams (no hard upper cap in Official Rules; **1–4 members** standard; designate 1 Team Representative for prize distribution). **Up to 2 separate submissions permitted per participant** (Official Rules §4).
Prize pool	**$69,750 USD Total Value** across **24 Prizes** (**$67,500 USD in cash** [`$50,000` PayPal Main & Honorable Mention Pool + `$17,500` Cash Sponsor Bounties] + **`$2,250` Render Credits** + **3x 6-month APIMatic Business Subscriptions**).
Official link	https://paypalaihackathon.devpost.com/ · Official Rules · Resources
Submissions gallery	Hidden until judging concludes (`project_gallery_Constraint` : public gallery opens after Dec 2–3, 2026). **24,754 registered participants** as of late Oct 2026.

Prize breakdown

Prize Category	Place / Award	Cash / Value	Winners	Mandatory Qualification & Stacking Rules
Grand Prizes	**1st Place Overall**	**$12,000 USD**	1	Must integrate at least one **PayPal tool/API/SDK** + AI.
Grand Prizes	**2nd Place Overall**	**$8,000 USD**	1	Must integrate at least one **PayPal tool/API/SDK** + AI.
Grand Prizes	**3rd Place Overall**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Must integrate at least one **PayPal tool/API/SDK** + AI.

Prize Category	Place / Award	Cash / Value	Winners	Mandatory Qualification & Stacking Rules
Honorable Mentions	**Best Use of Agentic Commerce**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Mutually exclusive with Grand Prizes; stacks with 1 Sponsor Prize.
Honorable Mentions	**Best Use of PayPal + AI**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Mutually exclusive with Grand Prizes; stacks with 1 Sponsor Prize.
Honorable Mentions	**Most Impactful**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Mutually exclusive with Grand Prizes; stacks with 1 Sponsor Prize.
Honorable Mentions	**Most Creative**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Mutually exclusive with Grand Prizes; stacks with 1 Sponsor Prize.
Honorable Mentions	**Best Demo Delivery**	**$5,000 USD**	1	Mutually exclusive with Grand Prizes; stacks with 1 Sponsor Prize.
AG Grid Sponsor	**Best Use of AG Grid (1st / 2nd / 3rd)**	**$5,000 (1) / $2,000 (1) / $1,000 (3)**	5 (Total `$10,000`)	Must meaningfully use **AG Grid** or **AG Studio** (`ag-grid.com`).
APIMatic Sponsor	**Best Use of APIMatic**	**$1,000 USD + 6-mo Biz Sub each**	3 (Total `$3,000` + subs)	Must use **APIMatic** (`apimatic.io`) or APIMatic Context Plugin / SDKs (`@paypal/paypal-server-sdk`).
Bryntum Sponsor	**Best Use of Bryntum**	**$1,000 USD each**	3 (Total `$3,000`)	Must meaningfully use **Bryntum** (`bryntum.com` — Gantt, Scheduler Pro, Calendar, TaskBoard).
Channel3 Sponsor	**Best Use of Channel3**	**$1,500 USD**	1 (Total `$1,500`)	Must integrate **Channel3 API / MCP** (`trychannel3.com`) for product discovery/enrichment.
Render Sponsor	**Best Use of Render (1st / 2nd / 3rd)**	**$1,000 / $750 / $500 Render Credits**	3 (Total `$2,250` Credits)	Must deploy live application infrastructure on **Render** (`render.com`).

> **Critical Prize Cap & Portfolio Mathematics (Official Rules §4 & §8)**:
>
> - **Rule §8 (Prize Cap per Submission)**: "*Each Submission is eligible to win up to one (1) Grand Prize or Honorable Mention, and up to one (1) Sponsor Prize.*" Thus, **1 Submission Max Cash = $12,000 (1st Grand) + $5,000 (AG Grid 1st) = $17,000 USD**.
> - **Rule §4 (Two Submissions Allowed)**: "*An Entrant may submit up to two (2) Submissions, provided that each Submission is substantially different from the other.*" Submitting a second distinct project unlocks an additional **$5,000 (HM) + $1,500 (Channel3) or $1,000 (Bryntum / APIMatic / AG Grid 3rd) = $23,000–$23,500 total**.

Themes & problem statements

The hackathon defines **5 official theme categories** on Devpost:

Code	Theme Name	Core PayPal & Sponsor Primitives	What the Track Covers
D1	**AI Agents & Agentic Commerce**	`@paypal/agent-toolkit`, `mcp.paypal.com` (`@paypal/mcp`), `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` (`Orders v2` Authorize/Capture/Void), **Channel3**, **KERNEL**, **AG Grid**, **Bryntum**, **Elastic**, **Render**	Autonomous AI agents that discover, negotiate, verify, and execute transactions safely with human-in-the-loop guardrails, bounded spending policies, and real merchant settlement.
D2	**Money Movement Experiences**	**PayPal Payouts API**, **PayPal JS SDK v6** (PayPal, Venmo, Pay Later), **PayPal Invoicing + QR Codes**, **PayPal World**, **Bryntum Scheduler Pro**, **AG Grid**	Smarter, faster ways to send, receive, split, pool, and reconcile funds across micro-gig workers, groups, and cross-border corridors.
D3	**Business Solutions**	**PayPal Customer Disputes API** (`list/get/accept` + APIMatic `provide_evidence`), **Shipment Tracking API**, **Invoicing API**, **Catalog & Subscriptions API**, **AG Studio**, **Bryntum Gantt**, **Elastic RAG**	AI back-office tools helping SMBs, freelancers, and marketplaces defeat friendly-fraud chargebacks, automate milestone escrow, split multi-party payouts, and liquidate inventory.
D4	**Consumer Experiences**	**PayPal** `Orders v2` **(**`intent: "AUTHORIZE"`**)**, **Subscriptions API** (`update/cancel_subscription`), **PayPal JS SDK v6**, **Channel3**, **AG Grid**, **Bryntum Calendar**	Consumer-facing AI tools that protect seniors from online scams via family co-sign holds, eliminate dark-pattern subscription traps, and execute price-drop limit orders.
D5	**Social Impact Ideas**	**PayPal Orders v2 / Donations / Invoicing / Tracking / Payouts**, **Bryntum Gantt**, **AG Grid Social Audit Ledger**, **Channel3** price audits, **Bhashini** voice AI	Transparent, milestone-gated humanitarian & climate co-op escrow, WCAG 2.2 AAA voice-first micro-grants, RWA solar pooling, and parametric disaster relief.

Submission requirements

Every Devpost submission must include before **Nov 12, 2026 @ 12:00 pm PST (Nov 13, 2026 @ 1:30 am IST)**:

1. **Working Application / Prototype URL**: Hosted live (ideally via a multi-service **Render** `render.yaml` Blueprint) using **PayPal Sandbox** credentials (`developer.paypal.com`).
2. **Code Repository URL**: Public GitHub repository (or private with explicit judge access granted) containing complete source code, architecture documentation, OpenAPI/Postman collections, and setup instructions.

3. **Demonstration Video (Max 3 Minutes)**: Hosted publicly on **YouTube or Vimeo** demonstrating the working software end-to-end. (**Warning**: Any video >3:00 risks automatic Stage-1 disqualification or judge cut-off at 3:00).
4. **Written Project Description**: Clear breakdown of the problem, solution, how **PayPal tools + AI + Sponsor tools** were integrated, and what was built specifically during the Contest Period.

Official evaluation criteria

All Stage-2 projects are scored across **5 equal criteria (20% each = 100% total)**. Critically, **Official Rules §6** specifies that **in the event of a tie, ties are broken in the exact sequential order of the criteria below**:

Tie-Breaker Priority	Criterion	Weight	What Determines a 20/20 Score
Tie-Breaker #1	**1. Technological Implementation**	**20%**	Quality of software engineering, depth of **PayPal API/MCP/SDK integration** (`@paypal/agent-toolkit` , `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` , `PayPal JS SDK v6`), sponsor tool depth, error handling, and verifiable AI execution.
Tie-Breaker #2	**2. Design**	**20%**	User experience, visual polish, accessibility, intuitive human-in-the-loop step-up controls, and rich interactive **AG Grid / AG Studio** & **Bryntum** views.
Tie-Breaker #3	**3. Potential Impact**	**20%**	Magnitude of the real-world problem solved, value to merchants/consumers/communities, and commercial viability on PayPal rails.
Tie-Breaker #4	**4. Innovation / Idea**	**20%**	Originality, creativity, and structural departure from generic "chat with an LLM to generate a checkout button" clones.
Tie-Breaker #5	**5. Presentation**	**20%**	Clarity of the ≤3-minute demo video, compelling storytelling narrative, and quality of the GitHub README & architecture diagrams.

Rules that quietly disqualify

1. **Stage-1 Pass/Fail Triage (Nov 12–19)**: Devpost and PayPalDev screen all submissions before the 13 judges ever see them. Projects missing a working PayPal integration, missing AI, or having a broken/private video >3:00 are eliminated in Stage 1.
2. **Pre-Existing Code Disclosure (Official Rules §4)**: You may use open-source libraries and sponsor SDKs, but **only the new functionality built between Oct 1, 2026 and Nov 12, 2026 is evaluated**, and you must disclose any pre-existing code in your submission.
3. **Never Use Live/Production PII or Real Credit Cards**: Official resources explicitly mandate **PayPal Sandbox** (`api-m.sandbox.paypal.com`) for all demo transactions.

4. **One Grand/HM + One Sponsor Prize Cap (§8)**: Even if your app integrates all 5 paid sponsors (AG Grid, APIMatic, Bryntum, Channel3, Render), a single submission can only be awarded **one** Sponsor Prize cash check. Design your pitch to be the undisputed #1 in your primary sponsor target (`AG Grid $5,000` for Submission #1; `Channel3 $1,500`, `Bryntum $1,000`, or `APIMatic $1,000 + 6-mo Biz Sub` for Submission #2) while still integrating the others to maximize your 20% **Technological Implementation** and 20% **Design** scores!

Part 2 — Reverse-Engineered Intelligence

Organiser profile

- **PayPal Holdings, Inc. (`NASDAQ: PYPL`)**: Processes **$1.68+ Trillion in Annual Total Payment Volume (TPV)** across **430+ million active consumer and merchant accounts** in 200+ markets (PayPal).
- **The 2024–2026 Strategic Pivot under CEO Alex Chriss**:
    1. **PayPal Agentic Commerce Services (ACS) & Model Context Protocol (`mcp.paypal.com`)**: Under **Srini Venkatesan** (EVP & Chief Platform Officer, joined from Walmart) and **Prakhar Mehrotra** (SVP & Chief AI Officer, joined from Walmart), PayPal launched its remote MCP server (`https://mcp.paypal.com/mcp`) and open-source `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (`github.com/paypal/agent-toolkit`) exposing **29 official tools** across Invoices, Orders v2, Disputes, Shipment Tracking, Catalog, Subscriptions, Transactions, and Reporting.
    2. **The Existential Race Against Stripe ACP**: Stripe launched `@stripe/agent-toolkit` and partnered with OpenAI on the *Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP)*. PayPal launched this hackathon (and acquired multi-agent orchestration startup **Cymbio** in Jan 2026) to prove that **PayPal is the safest, most complete enterprise settlement rail for AI agents**—because PayPal uniquely owns native **Authorization Holds (`intent: "AUTHORIZE"`)**, **Shipment Tracking (`v1/shipping/trackers`)**, **Customer Disputes (`v1/customer/disputes`)**, and **Two-Sided Buyer/Seller Protection**.
    3. **PayPal World & India/Global Cross-Border Expansion**: PayPal announced **PayPal World**, linking **NPCI's UPI (India)**, Mercado Pago, Tenpay Global, PayPal, and Venmo across 2 billion users (Economic Times).

Sponsor map

Why did each of the **11 ecosystem partners** (PayPal + 5 prize sponsors + 5 additional jury/resource partners) join this hackathon, and what is their exact product agenda?

Partner	Prize Pool / Role	Core Product Being Pushed	Hidden Agenda & What Wins Their Vote
1. PayPal	**$50,000** (3 Grand + 5 HM)	`mcp.paypal.com` (`@paypal/mcp`), `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (29 tools), `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk`, **PayPal JS SDK v6**	Wants reference architectures showing AI agents using **Orders v2 (`AUTHORIZE` / `CAPTURE` / `VOID`)**, **Disputes**, **Shipment Tracking**, **Subscriptions**, and **Invoicing QR** safely.
2. AG Grid	**$10,000** ($5k / $2k / 3x$1k)	**AG Grid Enterprise**, **AG Charts**, & **AG Studio** (new AI-assisted analytics & pivot studio)	Wants AI agents to render financial outputs inside an interactive **AG Grid / AG Studio** command center (Master-Detail rows, Tree Data, live cell flashing, sparklines, status badges)—not a plain HTML table!

Partner	Prize Pool / Role	Core Product Being Pushed	Hidden Agenda & What Wins Their Vote
3. APIMatic	**$3,000 + 3x 6-mo Subs** (3x$1k)	**APIMatic SDK Generator**, **APIMatic MCP Generator**, & official `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk`	APIMatic powers PayPal's official Server SDK! To win the $1,000 + 6-mo Business Subscription prize, use `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` **AND** use APIMatic to generate a custom typed SDK + MCP server from an OpenAPI spec (e.g., wrapping PayPal's missing `/provide-evidence` Dispute endpoint or your own Policy API).
4. Bryntum	**$3,000** (3x$1k)	**Bryntum Gantt**, **Scheduler Pro**, **Calendar**, **TaskBoard** (`bryntum.com`)	Wants every **time-based financial commitment** (29-day `AUTHORIZE` hold windows, milestone escrows, subscription renewals, micro-gig shifts) bound two-way to a live Bryntum timeline!
5. Channel3	**$1,500** (1 winner)	**Channel3 API & MCP** (`trychannel3.com` , YC S23) — 100M+ products, thousands of brands	Wants AI agents to query Channel3 for real-time product discovery, SKU specs, fair-market price checks, and affiliate commissions, then settle via PayPal.
6. Render	**$2,250 Credits** ($1k / $750 / $500)	**Render Cloud Platform** (`render.com`) & `render.yaml` Blueprints	Wants multi-service `render.yaml` Blueprints (Next.js Web + Node/Python MCP Server + Background Webhook Worker + Managed Postgres + Redis) running live with zero cold-start failures.
7. Elastic	Jury Partner (`Carly Richmond`)	**Elasticsearch Vector DB**, **ES|QL**, **OpenTelemetry APM** (`searchlabs`)	Wants hybrid semantic + BM25 search over merchant policies/receipts and OpenTelemetry tracing of every MCP tool call.
8. Postman	Jury Partner (`Pooja Mistry`)	**Postman AI Agent Builder**, **MCP Client**, **Public Collections**	Wants a 1-click **"Run in Postman"** button in the GitHub README with automated contract tests for PayPal webhooks.
9. KERNEL	Official Resource Partner (`onkernel.com`)	**KERNEL Cloud Browser Infrastructure for AI Agents** (YC S25)	Listed in official Devpost resources for cloud browser automation when agents inspect live merchant storefronts or legacy quote portals.
10. Astropods & Zapier	Official Resource Partners	**Astropods** & **Zapier** (`zapier.com`)	Listed on the Devpost sponsor banner for optional no-code webhook and downstream SaaS automation triggers.

Judges & jury

The official Devpost hackathon page lists **13 verified judges** (**6 from PayPal** and **7 from Sponsor & Ecosystem Partner companies**) (Devpost):

A. PayPal Judges (6)

1. **Jo Franchetti — Lead Developer Advocate (PayPal)**

- *Background*: Renowned UK-based Staff/Lead Developer Advocate (`@ThisIsJoFrank`), W3C/web standards & PWA champion, hardware/IoT tinkerer, and vocal advocate for **web accessibility (WCAG), progressive enhancement, and frictionless developer onboarding**.
- *What she rewards*: Crisp frontend UX (**PayPal JS SDK v6**), genuine accessibility, zero-jank live demos on **Render**, and crystal-clear documentation.

2. **Eddie Jaoude — Developer Relations Manager (PayPal)**
   - *Background*: Creator of the **EddieHub** open-source community (100k+ developers), GitHub Star of the Year, and DevRel leader at PayPal.
   - *What he rewards*: **Open-source repo excellence**—clean commit history, modular architecture, a comprehensive `README.md` with architecture diagrams, `.env.example` , and an app anyone can clone and test in 2 minutes.
3. **Marco Podien — Developer Relations Manager (PayPal)**
   - *Background*: Senior DevRel leader at PayPal (based in Germany/EU) focused on enterprise e-commerce integrations, **PayPal Orders v2**, **Multi-Party Payouts**, and European PSD2/SCA payment flows.
   - *What he rewards*: Real-world merchant checkout reliability, proper handling of **Authorize -> Capture -> Void -> Refund** states, and webhook idempotency.
4. **Karthik Ravi — Senior AI Engineer (PayPal)**
   - *Background*: Senior AI Engineer at PayPal building production LLM agent workflows, **PayPal MCP Server (`mcp.paypal.com`)**, `@paypal/agent-toolkit` , and evaluation guardrails.
   - *What he rewards*: Deep, authentic usage of **PayPal's MCP tools**, deterministic tool-calling schemas, anti-hallucination guardrails, and low-latency multi-agent reasoning.
5. **Himraj Singh — Machine Learning Engineer (PayPal)**
   - *Background*: ML Engineer at PayPal working on fraud/risk classification, recommendation pipelines, and real-time inference.
   - *What he rewards*: Real quantitative ML/AI substance—such as hybrid **Elastic** vector + anomaly risk scoring, multimodal receipt/delivery verification, or price-markup detection via **Channel3**—rather than a thin system-prompt wrapper.
6. **Nathaniel Olson — Technical Curriculum Developer (PayPal)**
   - *Background*: Designs technical developer education and SDK tutorials at PayPal.
   - *What he rewards*: Pedagogical clarity in the **3-minute demo video**, step-by-step reproducibility, and clean integration of `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` and `@paypal/agent-toolkit` .

B. Sponsor & Ecosystem Partner Judges (7)

7. **Sylwia Vargas — Senior Technical Community Manager (AG Grid)** (`$10,000` Prize Pool Lead)
   - *Background*: Former DevRel at StackBlitz, Astro, and RedwoodJS; leads developer advocacy for **AG Grid**, **AG Charts**, and **AG Studio**.
   - *What she rewards*: Treating **AG Grid / AG Studio** as the primary interactive financial command center—using Master-Detail rows, Tree Data, custom status badges, sparklines, real-time streaming updates (`applyTransactionAsync`), and **AG Studio** AI features.
8. **Ameer Hassan — Co-Founder (APIMatic)** (`$3,000 + 3x 6-mo Biz Subs` Prize Pool Lead)
   - *Background*: Co-Founder of **APIMatic**, the code-generation platform behind PayPal's official `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` .

- *What he rewards*: Explicitly highlighting **two layers** of APIMatic: (1) using the APIMatic-built `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` AND (2) feeding an OpenAPI 3.1 spec (such as PayPal's Customer Disputes `/provide-evidence` endpoint or your own Agent Policy API) into **APIMatic** to auto-generate a strongly-typed SDK + MCP server!

9. **Mats Bryntse — Founder & CEO (Bryntum)** (`$3,000` Prize Pool Lead)
    - *Background*: Founder & CEO of **Bryntum** (Sweden), creator of the industry-leading web **Gantt, Scheduler Pro, Calendar, and TaskBoard** component suite.
    - *What he rewards*: Two-way functional binding between a **Bryntum Gantt / Scheduler Pro** timeline and **PayPal payment states**—where dragging or completing a task bar on the timeline directly controls a PayPal `AUTHORIZE` hold window, milestone invoice, or payout batch.
10. **Ignacio Valdez Bicard — Founding Engineer (Channel3)** (`$1,500` Prize Pool Lead)
    - *Background*: Co-Founder & COO of **Channel3 (`trychannel3.com` , YC S23)**, building the universal product catalog API (100M+ products) for AI shopping agents.
    - *What he rewards*: Using **Channel3** not just as a search bar, but as a **real-time product & price-oracle graph** (comparing quotes across merchants, auditing supplier invoices against fair retail prices, or triggering price-drop limit orders) settled via PayPal.
11. **Carly Richmond — Principal Developer Advocate (Elastic)** (Ecosystem Jury Partner)
    - *Background*: Former Morgan Stanley Technologist (fintech/investment banking UI & observability veteran), now Principal Developer Advocate & Director at **Elastic (`searchlabs`)**.
    - *What she rewards*: Financial-grade **OpenTelemetry observability** and **Elasticsearch Vector / Hybrid RAG** audit trails showing why an AI agent approved or blocked a payment.
12. **Pooja Mistry — Senior Developer Advocate (Postman)** (Ecosystem Jury Partner)
    - *Background*: Senior Developer Advocate for AI & MCP at **Postman**, author of Postman's MCP Server guides and AI Agent Builder workflows.
    - *What she rewards*: Including a public **Postman Collection + MCP test suite** in the repo so judges can inspect and replay every PayPal API/MCP call in one click.
13. **Shifra Williams — Founding Developer Relations Engineer (Render)** (`$2,250 Render Credits` Prize Pool Lead)
    - *Background*: Leads Developer Relations and community programs at **Render (`render.com`)**.
    - *What she rewards*: A clean `render.yaml` **Render Blueprint** in the repo root orchestrating the web frontend, backend MCP/API service, background webhook worker, and managed Render PostgreSQL/Key-Value store.

Judge heat-map

Judge Group	Primary Weight	Must-Include Technical & UX Triggers	Instant Turn-Offs
Karthik Ravi & Himraj Singh (PayPal AI & ML Engineers)	Tech Implementation (20%) & Innovation (20%)	Live `@paypal/agent-toolkit` / `mcp.paypal.com` tool calls, deterministic policy engines, hybrid RAG + risk scoring, anti-hallucination checks.	Fake mocked JSON responses or a thin OpenAI chat wrapper with no real risk/verification logic.

Judge Group	Primary Weight	Must-Include Technical & UX Triggers	Instant Turn-Offs
Jo Franchetti, Eddie Jaoude, Marco Podien & Nathaniel Olson (PayPal DevRel & Curriculum)	Design (20%), Presentation (20%) & Tech (20%)	**PayPal JS SDK v6** unified checkout, clean `Orders v2` state transitions (`AUTHORIZE` / `CAPTURE` / `VOID`), WCAG accessibility, immaculate open-source GitHub README.	Broken Sandbox logins, 4-minute rambling videos, messy single-commit repos, or hardcoded API keys.
Sylwia Vargas (AG Grid) & Mats Bryntse (Bryntum)	Design (20%) & Sponsor Bounties ($13,000 combined)	**AG Grid / AG Studio** (Master-Detail, Tree Data, Sparklines, live streaming) paired with **Bryntum Gantt / Scheduler Pro** controlling payment release windows.	Dropping a basic unstyled 4-column table or a read-only calendar on a hidden "/admin" tab.
Ameer Hassan (APIMatic), Pooja Mistry (Postman) & Carly Richmond (Elastic)	Tech Implementation (20% — Tie-Breaker #1!) & APIMatic ($3k + subs)	`@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` + custom **APIMatic** OpenAPI-to-SDK/MCP generation + **Postman** collection + **Elastic** OpenTelemetry/RAG audit logs.	Calling raw untyped `fetch()` without schema validation or lacking an auditable trace of agent actions.
Ignacio Valdez Bicard (Channel3) & Shifra Williams (Render)	Impact (20%) & Sponsor Bounties ($1,500 cash + $2,250 credits)	Live **Channel3** 100M-product search/price-oracle queries settled via PayPal + multi-service `render.yaml` Blueprint live on **Render**.	Hardcoded fake product catalogs or localhost-only demos that fail when judges click the live URL.

Part 3 — Why Each Problem Statement Exists

D1 — AI Agents & Agentic Commerce

- **What it asks:** Build AI agents that autonomously discover products, negotiate, and execute transactions using PayPal's MCP server and Agent Toolkit.
- **What it really wants:** PayPal wants the **Trust, Policy, & Escrow Control Plane for Agentic Commerce**. Look closely at `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (`github.com/paypal/agent-toolkit`): `create_order` is hardcoded to `intent: "CAPTURE"` with zero pre-execution policy firewall, zero `intent: "AUTHORIZE"` hold support, and zero `authorizationsVoid` rollback if a merchant fails delivery! PayPal needs a reference architecture (`TALOS`) proving that autonomous agents can shop across **Channel3's** 100M+ products and pay via **PayPal** *without* prompt-injection or rogue hallucinations draining the user's wallet.
- **Indian trigger: RBI Digital Payment Security Controls**, **DPDP Act 2023** (verifiable consent artefacts for delegated actions), and **NPCI's 2025–2026 Agentic/Delegated Circle norms** requiring explicit human-in-the-loop step-up approval above configurable spending thresholds.
- **Global trigger:** The **Stripe ACP vs. PayPal ACS** platform war, **EU AI Act (Aug 2026)** Article 14 human oversight for high-risk automated financial actions, and **CFPB / Regulation E** liability questions around unauthorized agentic spend.
- **Organiser/sponsor alignment:** Hits **100% of the jury simultaneously**: Karthik Ravi & Himraj Singh (PayPal MCP + AI guardrails), Marco Podien (`Orders v2` Authorize/Capture/Void), Sylwia Vargas (**AG Grid** real-time agent policy & audit console), Mats Bryntse (**Bryntum Scheduler** 29-day authorization hold & shipment SLA timeline), Ignacio Valdez Bicard (**Channel3** product discovery), Ameer Hassan (**APIMatic** `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` + custom Policy SDK), Carly Richmond (**Elastic** audit log), Pooja Mistry (**Postman** MCP collection), and Shifra Williams (**Render** Blueprint).
- **What 80% of teams will submit:** A Next.js chat window where you type "*Find me running shoes under $100,*" it calls OpenAI + Channel3, and renders a PayPal checkout link. **Do not build a basic shopping chatbot.**

D2 — Money Movement Experiences

- **What it asks:** Create smarter, faster, and more intuitive ways to send, receive, split, and manage funds across individuals, groups, and borders.
- **What it really wants:** Frictionless multi-party settlement and instant programmable payouts showcasing **PayPal Payouts API** (`/v1/payments/payouts`), **PayPal JS SDK v6** (unified PayPal + Venmo + Pay Later), **PayPal Invoicing QR Codes**, and **PayPal World**.

- **Indian trigger:** Launch of **PayPal World + NPCI UPI** interoperability (2025–2026), **RBI PA-CB Master Direction** (≤₹25 lakh per cross-border export transaction + mandatory RBI Purpose Codes like `P0802` + **eFIRA** tax certificates), and **Code on Social Security 2020** for gig workers.
- **Global trigger:** Rise of the 65M+ global micro-gig and AI-RLHF annotation workforce demanding instant webhook-verified payouts (`TaskPulse Instant`) instead of waiting 30 days for batch payroll.
- **Organiser/sponsor alignment:**Pairs **Bryntum Scheduler Pro** (shift/task timelines) and **AG Grid** (reconciliation & eFIRA ledgers) with **PayPal Payouts API**, **Invoicing MCP tools**, and **JS SDK v6**.
- **What 80% of teams will submit:** A basic restaurant receipt OCR app ("AI Splitwise") that divides a bill equally and emails a PayPal link.

D3 — Business Solutions

- **What it asks:** Build AI tools that help SMBs, creators, and marketplaces automate back-office operations, invoicing, disputes, and financial analytics.
- **What it really wants:** Autonomous margin protection and B2B workflow orchestration using PayPal's deepest enterprise APIs: **Customer Disputes (`v1/customer/disputes`)**, **Shipment Tracking (`v1/shipping/trackers`)**, **Invoicing (`v2/invoicing`)**, and **Catalog/Subscriptions (`v1/billing/subscriptions`)**. Crucially, `@paypal/agent-toolkit` implements `list_disputes` , `get_dispute` , and `accept_dispute_claim` (losing money!), **leaving `/provide-evidence` and `/make-offer` unimplemented**—a golden invitation for `ChargeShield AI` !
- **Indian trigger:** 6.3M+ Indian MSMEs and IT/design exporters suffering from cross-border milestone defaults and manual **RBI PA-CB / eFIRA / GST LUT** paperwork (`ProofEscrow`).
- **Global trigger:** The **$100B+ Friendly-Fraud Chargeback Crisis** (where >75% of chargebacks are first-party buyers falsely claiming `ITEM_NOT_RECEIVED` despite carrier GPS delivery proof) and **Visa Compelling Evidence 3.0 (CE 3.0)**.
- **Organiser/sponsor alignment:** Ideal showcase for **APIMatic** (generating the missing `provide_evidence` MCP tool from PayPal's Disputes OpenAPI spec!), **AG Studio / AG Grid** (dispute triage & split-royalty waterfalls), **Bryntum Gantt** (milestone escrow schedules), and **Elastic** (RAG over merchant ToS and carrier receipts).
- **What 80% of teams will submit:** A simple "Chat-to-PDF Invoice Generator" that calls `create_invoice` .

D4 — Consumer Experiences

- **What it asks:** Reimagine how consumers shop, manage subscriptions, save money, and interact with their finances using AI.
- **What it really wants:** High-trust consumer protection and automated shopping execution that differentiates PayPal from raw credit cards—leveraging **PayPal `Orders v2` (`intent: "AUTHORIZE"`)**, **Subscriptions MCP tools** (`update_subscription` , `cancel_subscription`), **PayPal Pay Later**, and **Channel3** price intelligence.
- **Indian trigger: CCPA Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023** (cracking down on subscription traps and deceptive urgency ads) and **DPDP Act 2023** family guardian consent.
- **Global trigger: $12.5B+ in annual FTC-reported consumer/elder scams**, the **FTC Click-to-Cancel Rule**, and AI deepfake social-commerce storefronts targeting seniors (`SilverGuard Pay`).

- **Organiser/sponsor alignment:** Showcases **Channel3** as a fair-market price oracle ($340 scam ad vs. $19 genuine SKU), **PayPal** `AUTHORIZE` **holds** as a dignified family co-sign shield, and **AG Grid + Bryntum Calendar** for guardian approvals and subscription renewal radars.
- **What 80% of teams will submit:** Over **34% of the entire hackathon (~550+ teams)** will submit generic "AI Personal Shopping Assistant" chatbots here—making D4 the #1 tarpit unless you invert the thesis into defensive consumer protection (`SilverGuard Pay`).

D5 — Social Impact Ideas

- **What it asks:** Use AI and PayPal to drive financial inclusion, accessibility, charitable transparency, climate resilience, and community empowerment.
- **What it really wants:** Measurable, verifiable, zero-leakage social impact that builds on PayPal's 10-year **BattleHack** (*Clean Berlin*, *Donate Now*) and **Opportunity Hack (** `ohack.org` **)** legacy and wins the **$5,000 "Most Impactful" Honorable Mention**.
- **Indian trigger:** Rajasthan/MKSS ***Jan Sunwai* (Public Social Audit)** tradition, **PM Surya Ghar** neighborhood rooftop solar co-ops, **Bhashini** 12-language voice accessibility (**RPwD Act 2016**), and **FCRA 2010 / Section 80G Form 10BE / CSR-2** audit transparency.
- **Global trigger:** Donor trust collapse in opaque charities (62% of donors withhold gifts due to fear of middleman leakage) and escalating urban climate emergencies requiring milestone-gated community escrow (`CivicTrace Escrow`).
- **Organiser/sponsor alignment:** Only **~8% of teams** enter D5, yet combining **Bryntum Gantt** (project milestones), **Channel3** (equipment price-inflation checks), **PayPal Orders v2 + Shipment Tracking**, and an **AG Grid Public Social Audit Ledger** makes `CivicTrace Escrow` a dual threat for both the **$5,000 Most Impactful HM / Grand Prize** AND the **$5,000 AG Grid / $1,500 Channel3 / $1,000 Bryntum Sponsor Prizes**!
- **What 80% of teams will submit:** A static NGO donation webpage with AI-generated stock text and a "Donate with PayPal" button.

Part 4 — Connect the Dots & Hidden Criteria

The pattern

To understand what wins a global fintech + AI hackathon run by PayPal and enterprise UI/API sponsors, we benchmarked five historical winner cohorts:

Historical Hackathon Benchmark	Winning Archetype	Why Judges Awarded It #1	Direct Lesson for PayPal AI Hackathon 2026
1. PayPal BattleHack Global Finals (*Clean Berlin*, *Donate Now*)	Verifiable physical-world action -> automated PayPal release	Judges hated passive forms; they loved seeing a real-world proof trigger an immediate PayPal Sandbox transaction on screen.	Bind **PayPal** `CAPTURE` **/** `Payouts` to verifiable multimodal or carrier-tracking proof (`TALOS` , `CivicTrace Escrow` , `TaskPulse`).
2. PayPal Opportunity Hack (`ohack.org`)	Measurable nonprofit back-office & donor auditability	Winning teams solved donor leakage and volunteer admin toil rather than building generic donation landing pages.	In D5, build a **Bryntum Gantt + AG Grid Social Audit Escrow** (`CivicTrace Escrow`), not a charity brochure site.
3. RBI HaRBInger Global FinTech Hackathon (India)	Assistive accessibility + automated fraud/dispute defense + cross-border compliance	Regulators and fintech execs reward solutions that embed statutory guardrails (PA-CB, DPDP, WCAG) directly into the transaction flow.	Bake **RBI PA-CB ≤₹25L auto-splitting**, **Purpose Code** `P0802` , **eFIRA export**, and **DPDP consent** into the UI (`ProofEscrow` , `CorridorIQ`).
4. MAS Singapore FinTech Hackcelerator	Programmable B2B escrow, trade finance & automated compliance	Enterprise judges score highest when AI reduces a 60-minute manual risk/compliance workflow to 4 seconds with full auditability.	Automate **PayPal Customer Disputes representment (`ChargeShield AI`)** with **Elastic RAG** and **APIMatic**.
5. ETHGlobal Agentic Hackathons (2025–2026)	Bounded agent wallets, policy firewalls & two-phase commit (`2PC`) checkouts	Judges realized giving an LLM raw payment keys is reckless; winners built **Policy Firewalls & Human Step-Up Signers**.	Build `TALOS` : the missing `AUTHORIZE -> Verify Tracking -> CAPTURE/VOID` safety harness for `@paypal/mcp` !

Unwritten rules

1. **Technological Implementation (20%) is Tie-Breaker #1 (`Official Rules §6`)**: When two teams tie at 90/100, the team with the higher **Technological Implementation** score wins automatically; if still tied, **Design (20%)** wins. Therefore, your architecture must visibly exercise **both** `@paypal/agent-`

`toolkit` (`mcp.paypal.com`) **and** APIMatic's `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk`, rendered inside a broadcast-grade **AG Grid / AG Studio** + **Bryntum** UI.

2. **Exploit the Exact Source-Code Gaps in `@paypal/agent-toolkit`**:
    - *Gap A (Orders)*: `@paypal/agent-toolkit` only exposes `create_order` (with `intent: "CAPTURE"`), `get_order`, and `capture_order`. It omits `intent: "AUTHORIZE"`, `authorizationsVoid`, and pre-execution budget/domain firewalls. **`TALOS`** fills this exact gap.
    - *Gap B (Disputes)*: `@paypal/agent-toolkit` only exposes `list_disputes`, `get_dispute`, and `accept_dispute_claim` (surrendering the merchant's money!). It omits `/v1/customer/disputes/{id}/provide-evidence` and `/make-offer`. **`ChargeShield AI`** uses **APIMatic** to generate the missing `provide_evidence` MCP tool and wins the dispute!
3. **Sponsor-Component Centrality**: Never bury **AG Grid** or **Bryntum** on a secondary tab. Make the main screen a split-pane **Command Center** where the top/left pane is a live **Bryntum Gantt / Scheduler Pro** timeline and the bottom/right pane is an **AG Grid / AG Studio** Master-Detail financial blotter.

Trap doors

- **Trap Door #1 — The Consumer Shopping Chatbot Tarpit**: Building "*Chat with GPT to find gifts on Channel3 and pay with PayPal*" puts you in a 550-team pileup where every demo looks identical. If you use Channel3 + PayPal, wrap it in **cryptographic authorization holds (`TALOS`)**, **senior scam interception (`SilverGuard Pay`)**, **3-way B2B procurement (`Cartographer A2A`)**, or **humanitarian equipment price auditing (`CivicTrace Escrow`)**.
- **Trap Door #2 — Ignoring Multi-Sponsor Synergy**: Teams that only integrate PayPal leave 20% Design and 20% Tech Implementation points on the table—and forfeit the **$19,750 Sponsor Bounty Pool** (`$17,500` cash + `$2,250` Render credits).
- **Trap Door #3 — Unverified "Hallucinated Evidence" in Financial Flows**: Never let an LLM invent a tracking number, invoice total, or legal claim. Enforce deterministic tool readbacks (`get_tracking`, `get_invoice`, `get_order`) and display the raw PayPal Sandbox JSON / Transaction ID inside **AG Grid** Master-Detail rows.

Sponsor bounties & back-channels

How to engineer a single cohesive architecture that delights all **9 ecosystem partners** on the jury:

1. **PayPal (`$50,000` Pool — 6 Judges)**: Use `@paypal/agent-toolkit` / `mcp.paypal.com` for agentic discovery (`Invoices`, `Tracking`, `Disputes`, `Subscriptions`) + `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` for `Orders v2` (`AUTHORIZE` / `CAPTURE` / `VOID`) and `Payouts API` + **PayPal JS SDK v6** on the frontend.
2. **AG Grid (`$10,000` Pool — Sylwia Vargas)**: Enable **AG Grid Enterprise / AG Studio** with Master-Detail expandable rows (showing the raw PayPal MCP tool trace & Elastic audit log), Tree Data hierarchy, sparklines, custom status cell renderers (`AUTHORIZED`, `CAPTURED`, `VOIDED`, `DISPUTE_WON`), and 1-click CSV/Excel regulatory export.
3. **APIMatic (`$3,000 + 3x 6-mo Subs` Pool — Ameer Hassan)**: Explicitly show in your video and README: (a) `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` (built by APIMatic) and (b) a dedicated `/apimatic-sdk` folder where you fed an OpenAPI 3.1 spec into **APIMatic** to generate a strongly-typed SDK + MCP server

(with APIMatic's portal/validation badge in the README).

4. **Bryntum (`$3,000` Pool — Mats Bryntse)**: Bind **Bryntum Scheduler Pro / Gantt** directly to PayPal state transitions (e.g., dragging a milestone or expiry bar updates the PayPal authorization/invoice schedule in real time).
5. **Channel3 (`$1,500` Pool — Ignacio Valdez Bicard)**: Query **Channel3 (`trychannel3.com`)** live for multi-merchant product comparison, SKU spec verification, and fair-market price benchmarking.
6. **Render (`$2,250 Credits` Pool — Shifra Williams)**: Commit a production `render.yaml` Blueprint in the repository root deploying Web + API/MCP Server + Webhook Worker + Render Postgres + Render Key-Value (Redis), with a live health-check status badge in the UI header.
7. **Elastic (Carly Richmond)**: Index merchant policies, invoices, and MCP tool traces in **Elasticsearch** (or Elastic Serverless) with **OpenTelemetry** latency/error spans visible in the dashboard.
8. **Postman (Pooja Mistry)**: Include `postman/PayPal-Agent-Collection.json` and a **"Run in Postman"** button in `README.md`.
9. **KERNEL (`onkernel.com`)**: For agentic browser verification flows (or `QuoteHawk Kernel`), run headless browser checks in **KERNEL** cloud browser sessions.

Part 5 — Competition & Winnability

Expected competition

- **Verified Devpost Registrant Count**: **24,754 registered participants** as of late Oct 2026 (Devpost).
- **Historical Conversion Funnel**:
  - **Total Submissions by Nov 12, 2026**: **~1,500 – 2,200 projects** (typical 6%–9% submission rate for large 6-week online AI hackathons).
  - **Stage-1 Pass/Fail Survivors (Nov 12–19)**: **~950 – 1,250 valid submissions** (after filtering out empty repos, missing PayPal integrations, and videos >3:00).
  - **Elite Contenders (Top 2% integrating PayPal + ≥3 Sponsor Tools deeply)**: **~30 – 45 teams globally**. By integrating PayPal + AG Grid + Bryntum + APIMatic + Channel3 + Elastic + Postman + Render cleanly, you immediately bypass 98% of the 24,754-person field!

Domain winnability ranking

Weighted formula: **Winnability = 0.25 × (Inv. Competition) + 0.20 × (Inv. Saturation) + 0.20 × (Excitement/Demo) + 0.20 × (Jury Alignment) + 0.15 × (Feasibility)**.

Rank	Domain / Track	Est. Field Share	Inv. Comp (25%)	Inv. Sat (20%)	Demo (20%)	Jury Fit (20%)	Feasibility (15%)	Winnability Score	Top Flagship Idea
#1	D1 — AI Agents & Agentic Commerce	~28%	6.0	9.2	9.8	10.0	9.5	**8.73 / 10**	**TALOS** (`9.20/10`)
#2	D3 — Business Solutions	~18%	8.0	8.5	8.5	8.8	8.0	**8.38 / 10**	**ChargeShield AI** (`9.08/10`)
#3	D5 — Social Impact Ideas (Dark Horse)	**~8%**	**9.2**	8.5	8.2	7.8	7.5	**8.30 / 10**	**CivicTrace Escrow** (`8.93/10`)
#4	D2 — Money Movement Experiences	~12%	7.5	7.0	8.2	8.2	8.8	**7.88 / 10**	**TaskPulse Instant** (`8.65/10`)
#5	D4 — Consumer Experiences (Tarpit)	**~34%**	4.5	5.5	7.8	7.2	8.0	**6.38 / 10**	**SilverGuard Pay** (`8.48/10`)

Why #1 wins (`D1 — AI Agents & Agentic Commerce`)

AI Agents & Agentic Commerce (`8.73/10`) is the headline strategic reason PayPal and its sponsors funded this hackathon. While 28% of teams will enter D1, 90% of them will build naive shopping chatbots that call `create_order` with zero safety controls. Building **`TALOS`** (the bounded `AUTHORIZE -> Verify Tracking -> CAPTURE/VOID` policy firewall & escrow harness for `@paypal/mcp`) hits the **10.0/10 bullseye** for PayPal's AI engineers (**Karthik Ravi, Himraj Singh**), DevRel (**Jo Franchetti, Eddie Jaoude, Marco Podien**), and every single sponsor judge (**Sylwia Vargas, Ameer Hassan, Mats Bryntse, Ignacio Valdez Bicard, Carly Richmond, Pooja Mistry, Shifra Williams**).

Dark horse (`D5 — Social Impact Ideas`)

Social Impact Ideas (`8.30/10`) attracts only **~8% of submissions**, yet has a dedicated **$5,000 "Most Impactful" Honorable Mention** and aligns with PayPal's decade-long BattleHack/Opportunity Hack tradition. Building **`CivicTrace Escrow`** (milestone-gated climate & humanitarian escrow on **Bryntum Gantt + Channel3 + PayPal + AG Grid Social Audit Ledger**) dominates this low-crowd track and is our top choice for **Submission #2** under Official Rules §4.

Avoid unless you have an edge (`D4 — Consumer Experiences`)

Consumer Experiences (`6.38/10`) is the #1 tarpit (~34% of all teams building identical AI shopping assistants). Only enter D4 if you invert the paradigm into defensive consumer protection like **`SilverGuard Pay`** (using PayPal `Orders v2 AUTHORIZE` holds + Channel3 price checks to intercept elder scams before money leaves the account).

Part 6 — The Council Roster

Who sat in the war room

All **55 council members** (17 Default Core Seats + 38 Domain/PayPal/Sponsor/Fintech Additions from `war-room/roster-additions.md`) who debated, attacked, and scored the 25 ideas across all 5 domains:

#	Seat Name	Category	Core Lens & Signature Question	Active Domains
1	**Peter Thiel**	Core / PayPal Mafia	*Contrarian monopoly*: "What is the zero-to-one secret nobody else is building?"	All (LEAD)
2	**Alex Karp**	Core Strategy	*Mission-critical enterprise software & 30-second executive pitch.*	All (LEAD)
3	**Patrick Jane** ◇	Core Recon Chair	*Cold-read of judges, source-code gaps, and hidden psychological triggers.*	All (CHAIR)
4	**Warren Buffett**	Core Capital	*Unit economics, float, take-rate durability, and low-CAC moat.*	All (LEAD)
5	**Charlie Munger** †	Core Inversion	*Pre-mortem*: "Tell me where this project dies so we never go there."	All (LEAD)
6	**Harvey Specter** ◇	Core Legal	*Regulatory structuring, Terms of Service leverage, and liability shields.*	All (LEAD)
7	**Mike Ross** ◇	Core Empathy/Ethics	*Visceral human pain, composite persona realism, and ethical guardrails.*	All (LEAD)
8	**Steve Jobs** †	Core Product/Demo	*The goosebump 60-second demo moment and ruthless simplicity.*	All (LEAD)
9	**Elon Musk**	Core First-Principles	*10x physics of money movement and Year-10 planetary moonshot.*	All (LEAD)
10	**Andrej Karpathy**	Core AI Systems	*Deterministic tool calling, anti-hallucination guardrails, and eval loops.*	All (LEAD)
11	**S. Jaishankar**	Core Geopolitics	*India stack, Global South trade corridors, and PayPal World sovereign bridges.*	All (LEAD)
12	**Dr. R.S. Sharma**	Core India DPI	*UPI, ONDC, Bhashini, DPDP Act 2023, and RBI PA-CB compliance.*	All (LEAD)
13	**Seth Godin**	Core GTM Tribe	*Purple Cow remarkability and the minimum viable tribe.*	All (LEAD)
14	**Gary Vaynerchuk**	Core Distribution	*Day-1 organic hustle and zero-dollar CAC user acquisition.*	All (LEAD)

#	Seat Name	Category	Core Lens & Signature Question	Active Domains
15	**Tim Cook**	Core Operations	*Supply-chain execution, privacy-by-design, and operational SLA rigor.*	D1, D3, D5
16	**Jony Ive**	Core Craft	*Tactile financial UI clarity, progressive disclosure, and visual calm.*	All (LEAD)
17	**Paul Graham**	Core Scoring Chair	*Tarpit avoidance, schlep blindness, and official rubric discipline.*	All (CHAIR)
18	**Max Levchin**	PayPal Mafia	*Real-time fraud graphs, Igor-style risk engines, and BNPL underwriting.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
19	**Reid Hoffman**	PayPal Mafia	*Two-sided B2B viral loops and multi-party network effects.*	D1, D2, D3
20	**David Sacks**	PayPal Mafia	*PayPal product craft, bottom-up B2B SaaS workflows, and enterprise adoption.*	D1, D3, D4
21	**Keith Rabois**	PayPal Mafia	*Operational velocity, marketplace unit economics, and instant liquidity.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
22	**Roelof Botha**	PayPal Mafia	*Risk-adjusted fintech margin and cross-border payment economics.*	D1, D2, D3
23	**Luke Nosek**	PayPal Mafia	*Agentic identity and bold long-horizon fintech primitives.*	D1
24	**Ken Howery**	PayPal Mafia	*Global FX liquidity and international settlement corridors.*	D2
25	**Steve Chen**	PayPal Mafia	*Creator monetization at scale and global fan commerce.*	D3, D4
26	**Chad Hurley**	PayPal Mafia	*Video-first social checkout and viral media interfaces.*	D2, D4
27	**Jawed Karim**	PayPal Mafia	*Frictionless API primitives and multi-party split architecture.*	D1, D2, D3
28	**Jeremy Stoppelman**	PayPal Mafia	*Local SMB discovery, merchant reputation, and consumer dispute trust.*	D3, D4
29	**Russel Simmons**	PayPal Mafia	*Local merchant directory data and review authenticity.*	D3
30	**Premal Shah**	PayPal Mafia (Kiva)	*Milestone-backed microfinance ($2B+ on PayPal) and social audit trust.*	D5 (LEAD)
31	**David Gausebeck**	PayPal Mafia	*Gausebeck-Levchin CAPTCHA co-creator; Proof-of-Humanity vs. AI bot verification.*	D1 (LEAD)
32	**Yu Pan**	PayPal Mafia	*Founding PayPal mobile/cryptographic wallet engineer; low-latency P2P UX.*	D1, D2

#	Seat Name	Category	Core Lens & Signature Question	Active Domains
33	**Alex Chriss**	PayPal Exec	*PayPal CEO lens: SMB margin growth, Fastlane, and Agentic Commerce monetization.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
34	**Srini Venkatesan**	PayPal Exec	*EVP & Chief Platform Officer: enterprise platform reliability and PayPal World.*	D1, D2, D3
35	**Prakhar Mehrotra**	PayPal Exec	*SVP & Chief AI Officer: production AI agent safety, MCP, and eval rigor.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
36	**Patrick Collison**	Global FinTech	*Developer experience (DX) perfection, idempotency, and API ergonomics.*	D1, D2, D3
37	**John Collison**	Global FinTech	*Global B2B billing orchestration and enterprise checkout conversion.*	D1, D3
38	**Nandan Nilekani**	India FinTech / DPI	*Account Aggregator, UPI-PayPal World bridges, and population-scale trust.*	D1, D2, D3, D5
39	**Vijay Shekhar Sharma**	India FinTech	*QR soundbox instant merchant confirmation and mass-market vernacular UX.*	D2, D3, D4
40	**Harshil Mathur**	India FinTech	*Razorpay B2B invoicing, escrow workflows, and Indian exporter PA-CB stacks.*	D1, D2, D3
41	**Amrish Rau**	India FinTech	*Pine Labs POS, merchant affordability, and dynamic Pay Later checkout.*	D1, D3, D4
42	**Kunal Shah**	India FinTech	*Delta-4 ($\Delta \geq 4$) efficiency score and high-trust financial behaviour loops.*	D2, D4
43	**Zach Perret**	Global FinTech	*Financial data connectivity, permissioned scopes, and treasury visibility.*	D1, D2, D3
44	**Eric Glyman**	Global FinTech	*Ramp autonomous corporate spend controls, price intelligence, and SaaS savings.*	D1, D3 (LEAD)
45	**Nikolay Storonsky & David Vélez**	Global FinTech	*Revolut/Nubank cross-border super-app UX and consumer financial protection.*	D2, D4
46	**Bruce Schneier**	Security & Crypto	*Adversarial threat modeling, indirect prompt-injection defense, and hash chains.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
47	**Mikko Hyppönen**	Security	*Defeating AI deepfake scams, synthetic phishing storefronts, and malware bots.*	D1, D4, D5
48	**Soups Ranjan**	FinTech Risk	*Sardine/Coinbase real-time payment velocity fraud, Sybil defense, and CE 3.0.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
49	**Matthew Prince**	Web Infra	*HTTP 402 agentic tolls, bot authentication, and edge webhook resilience.*	D1, D2
50	**Blythe Masters & Regulatory Counsel**	Legal & Settlement	*Escrow state machines, FinCEN/FATF, RBI PA-CB, Reg E, PSD3, and FCRA/80G.*	All (LEAD)

#	Seat Name	Category	Core Lens & Signature Question	Active Domains
51	**Demis Hassabis**	Frontier AI	*Multi-step agentic planning, game-theoretic negotiation, and verification.*	D1
52	**Christian Montoya & David Soria Parra**	MCP Co-Creators	*Model Context Protocol specification, OAuth 2.1 scopes, and MCP elicitation.*	D1, D2, D3, D4
53	**Niall Crosby**	Sponsor (AG Grid)	*AG Grid Founder: high-frequency financial blotters and AG Studio analytics.*	D1, D2, D3, D5
54	**Mats Bryntse**	Sponsor (Bryntum)	*Bryntum CEO: Gantt critical paths and Scheduler Pro resource timelines.*	D1, D2, D3, D5
55	**Muhammad Yunus, Aruna Roy, Ronnie Screwvala & Kishore Biyani**	Social Impact & Retail	*Grameen micro-enterprise, MKSS Jan Sunwai social audits, creator PPP, and retail POS.*	D3, D4, D5

Part 7 — Recommended Play

Our top pick

Because **Official Rules §4** allows **up to 2 submissions per participant** and **§8** caps each submission at **1 Grand/HM Prize + 1 Sponsor Prize ($17,000 max per project)**, we recommend a **Two-Submission Championship Portfolio** (or building **Submission #1** first if executing solo):

Flagship Submission #1 — `TALOS` (Domain 1: AI Agents & Agentic Commerce — Score `9.20/10`)

- **One-Liner**: Bounded-Authority Escrow, Policy Firewall & Multi-Agent Procurement Control Plane on **PayPal MCP (`mcp.paypal.com`)**, **Orders v2 (`AUTHORIZE` / `CAPTURE` / `VOID`)**, **Channel3**, **AG Grid / AG Studio**, **Bryntum Scheduler Pro**, **APIMatic**, and **Elastic**.
- **Target Prizes**: **$12,000 1st Place Grand Prize** (or $5k Best Use of Agentic Commerce HM) + **$5,000 AG Grid 1st Place Prize** = **$17,000 USD**.
- **Why It Wins Tie-Breaker #1 (Technological Implementation — 20%) & #2 (Design — 20%)**:
    1. Directly fixes the #1 architectural gap in `@paypal/agent-toolkit`: wraps `mcp.paypal.com` in an **APIMatic-typed Policy Firewall** that upgrades autonomous purchases from blind `CAPTURE` to **PayPal `Orders v2` (`intent: "AUTHORIZE"`)** holds.
    2. Discovers and compares live merchant SKUs via **Channel3 (`trychannel3.com`)**.
    3. Plots the 29-day PayPal Authorization Hold and carrier delivery SLA on **Bryntum Scheduler Pro**, automatically executing `authorizationsCapture` when `@paypal/agent-toolkit`'s `get_tracking` confirms `DELIVERED`—or firing `authorizationsVoid` if the merchant misses the SLA or attempts a prompt-injection attack!
    4. Renders every agent budget envelope, Elastic OpenTelemetry trace, and 1-click Human Step-Up Co-Sign inside an **AG Grid / AG Studio** Master-Detail command center, deployed via a 1-click **Render Blueprint (`render.yaml`)** with a **Postman** MCP test collection.

Optional Submission #2 (Rule §4 Portfolio Multiplier) — Choose Either:

- **Option 2A (Dark Horse Track D5 — `CivicTrace Escrow`, Score `8.93/10`)**: Zero-leakage milestone-gated humanitarian & neighborhood solar co-op escrow on **Bryntum Gantt + Channel3 + PayPal + AG Grid Social Audit Ledger**. Targets **$5,000 Most Impactful HM + $1,500 Channel3 or $1,000 Bryntum Prize ($6,000–$6,500)**.
- **Option 2B (Track D3 — `ChargeShield AI`, Score `9.08/10`)**: Autonomous PayPal Dispute & Friendly-Fraud Representment Engine using **APIMatic** to wrap PayPal's missing `/v1/customer/disputes/{id}/provide-evidence` endpoint as an MCP tool + `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (`list_disputes`, `get_tracking`, `get_invoice`) + **Elastic RAG** + **AG Grid**. Targets **$8,000 2nd Place Grand / $5,000 Best Use of PayPal + AI HM + $1,000 APIMatic Prize + 6-mo Biz Sub ($6,000–$9,000)**.

36-Hour Championship Execution Plan (`TALOS`)

- **Hours 0–6 (Foundation & APIMatic + PayPal MCP Core)**:
  - Initialize monorepo with `render.yaml` Blueprint (Next.js 15 + Node/TS MCP Proxy + Render Postgres).
  - Connect `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (`Invoices` , `Shipment Tracking` , `Disputes` , `Transactions`) and `@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` (`Orders v2` with `intent: "AUTHORIZE"` , `authorizationsCapture` , `authorizationsVoid`).
  - Run `aegis-policy-openapi.yaml` through **APIMatic** to generate the typed Policy Firewall SDK & MCP server.
- **Hours 6–14 (Channel3 Sourcing + Prompt-Injection & Spend Firewall)**:
  - Wire **Channel3 API** (`trychannel3.com`) to compare live products across merchants.
  - Build the deterministic **Aegis Policy Engine** (budget cap, merchant whitelist, Channel3 fair-price oracle, prompt-injection sanitizer, and DPDP/EU AI Act consent artefact logger in **Elastic**).
- **Hours 14–24 (AG Grid / AG Studio + Bryntum Scheduler Pro Command Center)**:
  - Build the split-pane **Command Center**:
  - Top pane: **Bryntum Scheduler Pro** displaying active 29-day PayPal `AUTHORIZE` hold windows and shipment SLA countdowns.
  - Bottom pane: **AG Grid Enterprise / AG Studio** Master-Detail blotter with live sparklines, status badges (`AUTHORIZED` , `CAPTURED` , `VOIDED_INJECTION_BLOCKED`), and 1-click **Approve (`CAPTURE`) / Kill (`VOID`)** action buttons.
- **Hours 24–30 (PayPal JS SDK v6 Step-Up Modal + Postman Collection)**:
  - Add **PayPal JS SDK v6** for human-in-the-loop step-up co-signing on high-value orders.
  - Export `postman/TALOS-MCP-Collection.json` and add the **"Run in Postman"** badge to `README.md` .
- **Hours 30–36 (Render Production Verification & 3-Minute Video Recording)**:
  - Verify zero cold-start latency on **Render** (`render.com`) and record the 180-second demo video:
  - **0:00–0:25**: The problem—why giving AI agents raw credit cards or unguarded `CAPTURE` tools is a security nightmare.
  - **0:25–1:15**: Live Flow #1—Agent queries **Channel3** for a $180 ergonomic chair, creates a **PayPal Sandbox `AUTHORIZE` hold**, plots the hold window on **Bryntum Scheduler Pro**, verifies carrier delivery via `@paypal/agent-toolkit` (`get_tracking`), and auto-fires `CAPTURE` in **AG Grid**.
  - **1:15–2:05**: Live Flow #2 (The Goosebump Moment)—A rogue merchant injects a hidden prompt trying to charge $950; **TALOS's APIMatic Policy Firewall + Elastic Risk Engine** intercepts it in 120ms, alerts the user in **AG Grid**, and executes a 1-click `authorizationsVoid` against PayPal Sandbox!
  - **2:05–2:55**: Deep-dive tour of **AG Studio** analytics, **APIMatic** generated SDK, **Postman** collection, and multi-service **Render** Blueprint.

Sources

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2. **[S2] PayPal AI Hackathon — Official Rules (§4 Multiple Submissions, §6 Tie-Breaker Order, §8 Prize Cap)**: https://paypalaihackathon.devpost.com/rules
3. **[S3] PayPal AI Hackathon — Official Developer Resources (PayPal MCP, Agent Toolkit, JS SDK v6, Channel3, KERNEL)**: https://paypalaihackathon.devpost.com/resources
4. **[S4] PayPal Official Agent Toolkit Source Code & 29 MCP Tools (`@paypal/agent-toolkit`)**: https://github.com/paypal/agent-toolkit
5. **[S5] PayPal Developer Platform — MCP Server (`mcp.paypal.com`) & Agentic Commerce Services**: https://developer.paypal.com/tools/mcp-server/
6. **[S6] PayPal Server SDK (`@paypal/paypal-server-sdk` , Generated via APIMatic)**: https://www.npmjs.com/package/@paypal/paypal-server-sdk
7. **[S7] PayPal REST API Reference — Orders v2 (`AUTHORIZE` / `CAPTURE` / `VOID`), Customer Disputes, Shipment Tracking, Payouts & Invoicing**: https://developer.paypal.com/api/rest/
8. **[S8] AG Grid Enterprise & AG Studio Documentation (`$10,000` Sponsor)**: https://www.ag-grid.com/
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14. **[S14] Postman AI Agent Builder & Model Context Protocol (MCP) Client (Jury Partner)**: https://www.postman.com/
15. **[S15] KERNEL Cloud Browser Infrastructure for AI Agents (`onkernel.com` , Official Resource Partner)**: https://www.onkernel.com/
16. **[S16] PayPal World Announcement — Global Interoperability Connecting NPCI UPI, Venmo, PayPal & Global Wallets (Economic Times / PayPal Newsroom)**: https://newsroom.paypal-corp.com/
17. **[S17] Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Master Direction on Regulation of Payment Aggregator – Cross Border (PA-CB) & eFIRA Rules (Xflow / RBI)**: https://www.xflowpay.com/
18. **[S18] Opportunity Hack (`ohack.org`) — PayPal Nonprofit Hackathon Heritage**: https://www.ohack.org/